



DEATH OF THE DINOSAURS

The first dinosaurs probably lived about 230 million years ago, and the last ones died out about 65 million years ago. Most experts believe that a 6-mile- (10-km-) wide asteroid struck Earth (near the present-day Mexican coastline), leaving a crater 110 miles (180 km) wide. This created a cloud of vaporized asteroid and Earth material that blotted out the Sun. Without light, plants died, so herbivorous (plant-eating) dinosaurs were wiped out, too. The chain continued, with their predators, the carnivorous (meat-eating) dinosaurs, starving to death. Though we know that an asteroid hit Earth, we do not have clear proof that it killed the dinosaurs.

"DINOSAURS MAY BE EXTINCT FROM THE FACE OF THE PLANET, BUT THEY ARE ALIVE AND WELL IN OUR IMAGINATIONS."

Steve Miller, American author

SURVIVING SPECIES

It wasn't just the dinosaurs that were wiped out by the extinction. Large reptiles and many land plants didn't make it either. Yet there were survivors. Small mammals, birds, and insects managed to live on after the disaster. Water-based creatures also fared very well. Bony fish, amphibians, and small reptiles, including crocodiles, lizards, and snakes, continued to flourish.

FUTURE EXTINCTION

It's a scary thought, but one day, people may be facing extinction, too. Another giant asteroid could hit Earth and wipe out all of the species living here. Perhaps repeated earthquakes and volcanic activity will eventually destroy the planet. With the rate at which different species are already dying out and energy supplies being used at an unsustainable rate, people could bring about their own demise and the end of the world as we know it.

NO SPRING CHICKEN

Surprisingly, chickens are modern-day dinosaurs. They are the closest living relatives to a bipedal type of dinosaur called a theropod. These feathered descendants of the dinosaur family tree share many of the same characteristics, including warm blood and hatching their young from eggs. In addition, recent research has found that molecules preserved in dinosaur fossils are very similar to chicken protein.